

Chapter-one

Introduction

Japanese literature boasts a rich and diverse tradition that spans over a millennium, reflecting the country's unique cultural, social, and philosophical evolution. Beginning with ancient texts such as the Kojiki and Nihon Shoki in the 8th century, which are foundational works that blend mythology, history, and the early formation of the Japanese state, literature gradually developed its distinctive form. The Heian period (794-1185) is often regarded as the golden age of Japanese classical literature, with works like *The Tale of Genji* by Murasaki Shikibu, considered the world's first novel, and *The Pillow Book* by Sei Shonagon offering a window into the aristocratic court life. During the medieval period, literature began to incorporate Buddhist and Confucian philosophies, while the Noh and Kabuki theater traditions blossomed, offering deep insights into the human condition. the early modern period, or Edo period (1603-1868), witnessed a flourishing of popular literature, with works like *The Tale of the Heike*, ukiyo-e (woodblock prints), and kabuki plays providing commentary on the dynamics of society.

It was also during this time that the haiku and chūshingura stories became integral to the Japanese literary canon. With the Meiji Restoration in 1868, Japan began to modernize, and Western influences began seeping into its literature. The late 19th and early 20th centuries saw authors like Netsuke Sōseki and Yukio Mishima exploring modern existential concerns and the tension between tradition and innovation. Post-World War II writers such as Haruki Murakami and Yukio Mishima introduced new ideas, blending Eastern and Western literary traditions while grappling with Japan's identity in a rapidly changing world Japanese literature throughout most of its history has been influenced by cultural contact with neighbouring Asian literature.

Sayaka Murata is a Japanese novelist whose works have gained international acclaim for their unflinching exploration of society, identity, and the struggle for personal freedom.

Born on July 14, 1979, in Inzai, Chiba Prefecture, Japan, Murata's literary career

reflects her unique perspective on the pressures of societal conformity and the complex human desire to break free from these constraints. Her works often present a contrast between the expectations placed on individuals by society and their own desires for autonomy and self-expression, especially for those on the fringes of social norms. Murata's background is both ordinary and extraordinary. Raised in a typical Japanese household, she initially studied literature at the University of Tokyo, where she began to hone her writing. However, her career as a writer didn't start in an immediately conventional way. She worked a variety of jobs before finding success as a novelist, and her experiences in different roles, including stints as a part-time convenience store worker, directly influenced her later works.

This particular job became the basis for her most famous novel, *Convenience Store Woman* published in 2016. The novel tells the story of Keiko Furukura, a woman in her 30s who has worked for years at the same convenience store, and whose identity is deeply tied to the routine and structure of the job. Murata portrays Keiko's contentment in her seemingly repetitive, small-scale life as a stark contrast to the overwhelming pressure to marry and conform to societal expectations, which she finds alienating. Through Keiko's character, Murata critiques social norms and the high value placed on traditional success, such as marriage and stable employment.

One of Murata's central themes is the alienation experienced by individuals who do not fit into society's conventional expectations. In addition to *Convenience Store Woman*, her other works also explore similar themes. *Earthlings* published in 2018, pushes these ideas even further, delving into the life of a young woman, Natsuki, who feels alienated from humanity and comes to believe that she is an extra terrestrial. The novel's unsettling, and at times grotesque, narrative explores issues like mental illness, trauma, and the extremes to which someone might go in order to escape the suffocating grip of societal norms. Murata's ability to turn the deeply personal into a broader social commentary is one of her defining features, as she invites readers to question what it means to be normal and to find peace within the chaos of human expectations. Murata's writing style is deceptively simple, yet rich to challenge readers to reconsider the nature of normality, identity, and fulfillment in modern society. *Sayava* is a thought-

provoking short story collection by Sayaka Murata, exploring themes of identity, relationships, and societal norms in contemporary Japan. The stories are characterized by Murata's unique narrative voice, which is both poignant and unsettling. Through her characters' experiences, Murata masterfully exposes the tensions between individual desire and societal expectations, revealing a world where the boundaries between reality and fantasy are increasingly blurred.

Life Ceremony(2019) is a captivating short story collection by Sayaka Murata, exploring the intricacies of human relationships, societal norms, and the complexities of contemporary Japanese life. The stories are woven together by Murata's masterful narrative voice, which is both subtle and profound. One of the most striking aspects of *Life Ceremony* is its exploration of the tensions between tradition and modernity, as characters navigate the expectations of family, community, and society. Murata's writing is both nuanced and evocative, conjuring a sense of intimacy and immediacy that draws the reader into the world of the stories. Through her characters' experiences, Murata exposes the fragility and beauty of human connection, revealing the ways in which relationships can both sustain and suffocate us. Ultimately, *Life Ceremony* is a powerful and haunting collection that challenges readers to confront the complexities and mysteries of human existence. *Jinan*(2003) is a poignant and thought-provoking novel by Sayaka Murata, exploring the complexities of human relationships, identity, and the fragility of the human condition. The story follows a young woman, struggling to come to terms with her past and find her place in the world. Through her experiences, Murata masterfully exposes the tensions between individual desire and societal expectations, revealing a world where the boundaries between reality and fantasy are increasingly blurred. With her characteristic nuance and empathy, Murata delves into the inner world of her protagonist, laying bare the deepest fears, desires, and contradictions that shape her life. The result is a powerful and haunting novel that challenges readers to confront the complexities and mysteries of human existence, and to question the very notion of what it means to be alive.

Earthlings(2018) is a haunting and introspective novel by Sayaka Murata, exploring the complexities of human identity, relationships, and the search for meaning in a seemingly

indifferent world. The story follows a young woman, Natsuki, who returns to her family's rural home after a traumatic experience, and finds herself increasingly disconnected from the world around her. As Natsuki's narrative unfolds, Murata masterfully exposes the tensions between individual desire and societal expectations, revealing a world where the boundaries between reality and fantasy are increasingly blurred. Through Natsuki's struggles to reconcile her past and present selves, Murata raises profound questions about the nature of identity, belonging, and what it means to be human.

Shirokuma Café(2012) is a charming and whimsical novel by Sayaka Murata, exploring the complexities of human relationships and identity through a unique and imaginative lens. The story takes place in a cozy café run by a polar bear, where a young woman named Sasako finds solace and companionship among the café's quirky patrons. As Sasako's narrative unfolds, Murata masterfully weaves together themes of loneliness, belonging, and the search for meaning, revealing a world where the boundaries between humans and animals are gently blurred. Through Sasako's experiences, Murata raises poignant questions about the nature of identity, community, and what it means to find one's place in the world.

A Clean Marriage(2001) is a thought-provoking novel by Sayaka Murata, exploring the complexities of marriage, identity, and societal expectations in contemporary Japan. The story revolves around a young couple, Miki and Yuichi, who appear to have a perfect marriage, but beneath the surface, they are struggling to maintain their relationship. Miki, the protagonist, is a meticulous and organized housewife who is obsessed with cleanliness and order, while Yuichi is a successful businessman who is increasingly distant and detached. As the narrative unfolds, Murata masterfully exposes the tensions and contradictions that underlie their marriage, revealing a world where the boundaries between public and private, cleanliness and dirt, are constantly blurred. Through Miki's experiences, Murata raises poignant questions about the nature of identity, relationships, and what it means to be a woman in Japanese society.

The Borrowed Life(2022) is a captivating short story collection by Sayaka Murata, exploring the complexities of human relationships, identity, and the power of stories to shape our lives. The stories in this collection are woven together by Murata's masterful narrative

voice, which is both poignant and unsettling. Each story delves into the inner world of its characters, exposing the intricate web of emotions, desires, and contradictions that shape their lives. Through her characters' experiences, Murata raises profound questions about the nature of identity, community, and what it means to be and that these stories can both liberate and constrain us. With her characteristic nuance and empathy, Murata crafts a narrative that is both deeply personal and universally relatable, inviting readers to confront the complexities and mysteries of human existence.

Vanishing World(2005) is a thought-provoking short story collection by Sayaka Murata, exploring themes of identity, relationships, and societal norms in contemporary Japan. The stories are characterized by Murata's unique narrative voice, which is both poignant and unsettling. Through her characters' experiences, Murata masterfully exposes the tensions between individual desire and societal expectations, revealing a world where the boundaries between reality and fantasy are increasingly blurred. One of the most striking aspects of *vanishing World* is its exploration of the human condition, delving into the complexities of loneliness, disconnection, and the search for meaning in a rapidly changing world. Murata's writing is both nuanced and evocative, conjuring a sense of unease and disorientation that lingers long after the stories have ended. *Empty nest*(2003) is a poignant and thought-provoking novel by Sayaka Murata, exploring the complexities of motherhood, identity, and relationships in contemporary Japan. The story follows Toshiko, a devoted mother who has dedicated her life to raising her children, and is now faced with the daunting reality of an empty nest. As her youngest child leaves the family home to attend university, Toshiko is left feeling lost and uncertain about her own identity, having sacrificed her own desires and aspirations for the sake of her family. Murata masterfully captures the nuances of Toshiko's emotional journey, as she grapples with the societal expectations placed upon her as a mother, and the limitations of her own role in Japanese society.

Honey I am Home(1999) is a captivating short story collection by Sayaka Murata, exploring the intricacies of family relationships, identity, and the human condition. The stories in this collection are woven together by Murata's masterful narrative voice, which is both

poignant and unsettling. Each story delves into the inner world of its characters, exposing the intricate web of emotions, desires, and contradictions that shape their lives. From the perspective of a wife who feels suffocated by her husband's expectations, to the inner turmoil of a mother struggling to connect with her teenage daughter, Murata's characters are multidimensional and relatable. Through their experiences, Murata raises profound questions about the nature of identity, community, and what it means to be human.

The last Resort(2009) is a haunting and introspective short story collection by Sayaka Murata, exploring the complexities of human relationships, identity, and the fragility of the human condition. The stories in this collection are set in a world where the boundaries between reality and fantasy are increasingly blurred, and where the characters are forced to confront the darker aspects of themselves and their societies. With her characteristic nuance and empathy, Murata delves into the inner worlds of her characters, exposing the intricate web of emotions, desires, and contradictions that shape their lives. From the perspective of a woman who becomes obsessed with a mysterious resort town, to the inner turmoil of a man struggling to come to terms with his past, Murata's characters are multidimensional and relatable. Through their experiences, Murata raises profound questions about the nature of identity, community, and what it means to be human in the face of adversity.

The Women in The Window(2004) is a gripping and atmospheric novel by Sayaka Murata, exploring the complexities of identity, isolation, and the human psyche. The story follows a recluse named Michiko, who has retreated from the world and spends her days spying on her neighbors from the comfort of her own home. As Michiko becomes increasingly obsessed with the lives of those around her, the boundaries between reality and fantasy begin to blur. When a new family moves in next door, Michiko's fascination with their lives reaches a boiling point, leading her to make a shocking discovery that challenges everything she thought she knew about herself and her place in the world.

Convenience Store Woman(2015) by Sayaka Murata is a novel about Keiko Furukura, a 36-year-old woman who has worked at the same convenience store for 18 years. Through Keiko's perspective, the novel explores themes of societal expectations, conformity, and personal

fulfilment. Keiko Furukura is an odd but content woman who has never fit into societal norms. From childhood, she struggled to understand social cues and emotions, often reacting in ways others found inappropriate. Her family worried about her inability to act “normal,” and she learned to mimic others to avoid standing out.

Finding Purpose in *the Convenience Store*(2016) At 18, Keiko starts working at the newly opened Smile Mart convenience store. The job provides her with a structured environment where she learns the proper way to interact with customers and colleagues. She memorizes the store manual and copies the behaviour of her co-workers, finally feeling like she belongs somewhere. Keiko's Routine and Happiness Now 36, Keiko has spent nearly two decades as a part-time convenience store worker. She takes pride in her work, ensuring the store operates smoothly. She finds comfort in the store's routine stocking shelves, greeting customers, and following company protocols. However, society views her lack of career ambition and unmarried status as abnormal. Keiko's family and friends constantly question why she hasn't pursued a more prestigious career or gotten married. Though she is content, their concern makes her feel as though she is failing at life. When she tells them she loves her job, they dismiss her feelings, assuming she must be unhappy.

One day, a new employee named Shiraha starts working at the store. He is an unemployed man in his late thirties, bitter about society's expectations. He believes that modern life is just a repetition of ancient survival tactics, where only those who conform are accepted. He complains about work and is eventually Shiraha, desperate for a place to stay, convinces Keiko to let him move into her tiny apartment. Keiko sees this as an opportunity to satisfy societal expectations if people think she has a boyfriend, they might stop questioning her life choices. In return, she provides for Shiraha while he does nothing. At first, Keiko enjoys the relief of not being judged, but she soon realizes that Shiraha is a burden. He is lazy, manipulative, and uninterested in contributing to their arrangement. He pressures her to find a better-paying job so she can support him, arguing that she needs to grow up.

Convenience Store Woman is a novel by Sayaka Murata, published in 2016. It tells the story of Keiko Furukura, a socially awkward woman who has worked at the same convenience

store in Tokyo for 18 years. The book explores themes of social conformity, individuality.

Keiko Furukura, the protagonist, is a 36-year-old woman who has worked at a Smile Mart convenience store since she was 18. Unlike her peers, she finds deep satisfaction in the predictability and order of her job. From childhood, Keiko has struggled to understand social norms, often taking things literally. She once stopped a playground fight by hitting a boy over the head with a shovel, not realizing this was inappropriate behavior. Her family, confused by her inability to conform, tries to “fix” her, but Keiko finds solace in the structured world of the convenience store.

At the store, Keiko follows the manual diligently, learning how to greet customers, arrange merchandise, and anticipate their needs. She mimics her coworkers’ speech and behavior to appear normal. The store becomes her world, and she sees herself as an integral part of its functioning. Despite her contentment with her job, Keiko feels pressure from society and her family to change. Her younger sister, Mami, is especially concerned that Keiko remains unmarried and in a low-status job. Keiko's friends and coworkers constantly ask why she hasn’t found a real career or a husband.

At work, Keiko carefully observes and mimics her colleagues to blend in. She adjusts her tone, expressions, and even diet to match those around her. This helps her avoid suspicion, but she remains an outsider. Society’s expectations begin to weigh on her as she realizes she is seen as a toy. Keiko's routine is disrupted when a new employee, Shiraha, joins the store. He is a bitter, lazy man who despises societal expectations but refuses to work hard. Shiraha frequently rants about how human society still follows ancient mating rituals, treating men as providers and women as nurturers. Unlike Keiko, Shiraha openly rejects social norms but offers no alternative solution. His poor work ethic leads to his dismissal, but Keiko finds him intriguing. She sees an opportunity: if she lives with Shiraha, society might finally accept her as normal. Keiko invites Shiraha to live with her. In return, she provides for him, allowing him to avoid work. Though Keiko has no romantic or sexual interest in Shiraha, she sees their cohabitation as a way to silence societal criticism. Her family and friends react positively, assuming she is finally conforming.

However, Shiraha is a selfish and parasitic presence. He spends his days loafing around, playing games, and complaining about society. He pressures Keiko to quit her job, arguing that it makes her seem abnormal. Though she resists, she eventually gives in and resigns from the store. Without the store, Keiko is lost. She struggles to fill her days and feels disconnected from the world. Though she has achieved a semblance of normality in the eyes of others, she feels hollow inside. She realizes that she has never truly desired a husband or a traditional career her real happiness came from being a convenience store worker. Keiko begins to see that pretending to be normal is making her miserable. Though she wanted to be accepted, she now understands that societal expectations do not align with her true self.

While accompanying Shiraha on a job-hunting errand, Keiko stops by a convenience store. As she listens to the store's beeping registers, rustling plastic bags, and employee greetings, she feels an overwhelming sense of belonging. She realizes that she is meant to be a convenience store worker it is not just a job but an identity. Keiko decides to break free from Shiraha's influence. She understands that trying to conform has only brought her distress. Instead of living according to society's expectations, she chooses to embrace her love for the convenience store and the life it provides. Keiko leaves Shiraha and immediately seeks a new convenience store job. As she walks into a store, she instinctively starts adjusting displays and straightening items, proving to herself that she is, at her core, a convenience store worker. The novel ends with Keiko reaffirming her identity. Though she will never be what society deems normal she has found happiness in her own way. She no longer needs to justify her existence she simply belongs in the world of the convenience store. For Keiko, work is more than a means of survival it gives her purpose. Her meticulous dedication to the store contrasts with society's view of it as a low-status job.

The novel questions why certain jobs are valued more than others and whether societal approval should dictate personal fulfillment. *Convenience Store Woman* is a poignant exploration of what it means to be an outsider in a conformist society. Keiko's journey is not about transformation but self-acceptance. By the end, she embraces her unconventional happiness, choosing authenticity over societal approval. The novel challenges readers to reflect

on their own lives: Are we living for ourselves or simply adhering to societal scripts? Keiko's story is a quiet but powerful rebellion against the idea that normalcy equates to fulfillment. Keiko leaves Shiraha and decides to return to convenience store work. She no longer cares about what others think, embracing her role as a convenience store worker with pride. She finds peace in knowing that she is exactly where she is meant to be, even if society sees her as strange. The novel challenges societal norms and celebrates individuality, showing that happiness comes from personal fulfillment, not external validation.

The significance of *Convenience Store Woman* lies in its sharp critique of societal expectations, its exploration of identity, and its reflection on modern work culture. Sayaka Murata uses Keiko Furukura's unconventional life to challenge the rigid norms that dictate career success, relationships, and gender roles, particularly in Japan. Through Keiko's experience as a longterm convenience store worker, the novel questions whether happiness must align with societal standards or if personal fulfillment can be found in unexpected places. The convenience store itself serves as both a symbol of stability and a critique of capitalism, highlighting the repetitive and mechanical nature of modern labour. Keiko's struggle with social adaptation and her reliance on mimicry suggest themes of neurodivergence, making her story relatable to those who feel pressured to mask their true selves to fit in. Additionally, the novel raises questions about loneliness, independence, and the societal tendency to view unconventional lifestyles as failures. Murata's minimalist, satirical writing style enhances the novel's impact, making it both humorous and unsettling. Through Keiko Furukura's unconventional life, the novel questions the idea that success and fulfillment must come from career advancement, marriage, or social conformity. It highlights the struggle of individuals who do not fit into traditional moulds and critiques the pressure to follow a standardized life path. Additionally, the book explores themes of identity and self-acceptance, particularly through Keiko's reliance on mimicry to navigate social interactions, which some interpret as a reflection of neurodivergence. The novel also serves as a commentary on capitalism and modern work culture, using the convenience store as a microcosm of structured, repetitive labour where workers are expected to function with robotic efficiency.

At its core, *convenience store women* encourages readers to reconsider the definition of normalcy and happiness, suggesting that fulfillment is deeply personal and does not have to align with societal expectations. Through its minimalist, satirical style, the novel presents a thought-provoking and humorous yet unsettling exploration of individuality, non-conformity, and the quiet rebellion of living life on one's own terms.

In *Convenience Store Woman*, Sayaka Murata explores cultural theory by examining how societal norms and expectations shape individual identity, particularly in Japanese society. The novel highlights Japan's strong emphasis on collectivism, where people are expected to conform to societal roles and maintain harmony. Keiko Furukura, the protagonist, struggles to fit into these rigid expectations, as she finds genuine fulfillment in her job at a convenience store, despite society viewing it as a low-status position. The Japanese work culture places significant importance on career progression and social standing, yet Keiko challenges this by remaining content in a job others see as temporary. Her continued work at the convenience store is viewed as abnormal, illustrating how societal norms dictate success and identity.

Another key cultural theme is gender expectations. Women in Japan are often pressured to marry and prioritize family over personal ambition. Keiko, however, has no interest in relationships, yet she faces persistent pressure from her family and peers to conform. Through the character of Shiraha, the novel critiques outdated gender roles, exposing how traditional expectations still shape modern society. Furthermore, the novel explores the othering of non-conformists, where those who do not follow conventional life paths are seen as strange or in need of fixing. Even though Keiko is happy with her lifestyle, others insist she must change, reflecting the societal intolerance toward individuality.

The convenience store itself serves as a symbol of modern Japanese society structured, efficient, and repetitive. Keiko finds comfort in its predictable routines, as it provides her with clear instructions on how to exist, something she struggles with in broader society. This setting represents both security and the rigid conformity demanded by Japanese culture. Ultimately, *Convenience Store Woman* critiques the cultural pressures that dictate identity, happiness, and success. It challenges readers to question whether societal expectations should define an

individual's worth or if personal fulfillment should take precedence. Murata's novel offers a sharp commentary on the conflict between cultural norms and personal agency, making it a profound reflection on modern Japanese society.

The project is divided into four chapters. The first chapter Introduction provides an overview of Japanese Literature and it further gives a brief survey of Sayaka Murata's life in convenience store and how society treated her and the struggles she faced as a single woman and it also gives details about Sayaka Murata's literary achievements her other works and it also provide a brief summary of *Convenience Store Woman*. The second chapter Gender Performativity focuses on the sufferings of Sayaka Murata in convenience store and social expectation on how women should be and she experienced emotional scar and that influenced her relationship with others this chapter also highlight Judith Butler's concept of gender performativity. the chapter also highlights how women are pressured to prioritize family over personal fulfillment and are often judged based on their adherence to feminine norms, such as emotional expressiveness and social conformity. Chapter four summation brings together the ideas from the previous chapter. It reviews the arguments and presents the researches findings.

The methodology used is in accordance with *MLA handbook for writers of research papers eighth edition*.

Chapter-two

Gender performativity

An incident in the novel underscores Keiko's perplexity regarding her emotions, particularly her inability to comprehend why she should prioritise certain individuals over others. Her statement, "Maybe this particular baby should be more important to me than the others," reflects her innate tendency to lack emotional attachment to those in her surroundings and her questioning of societal norms regarding familial prioritisation (55). In this context, Keiko emerges as an independent figure who challenges society's implicit expectation of prioritising family over other individuals.

Keiko's departure from conventional behaviour distinguishes her from mainstream societal norms, resulting in her ostracization. However, Thornbury, in her research article on Keiko, argues that there are compelling reasons to appreciate her distinct perspective and contributions. She says that Keiko may not earn much from her job, but she embodies independence and self-reliance. She offers warmth and comfort to customers, particularly the elderly, with her cheerful greetings and friendly interactions.

One of her most admirable traits is her quiet defiance against those who belittle her for her job. Keiko finds it intriguing when people look down on her for working in a convenience store, and she boldly confronts their judgmental attitudes. She challenges societal biases and offers a different perspective on what it means to be human. In essence, "Keiko offers a corrective in her own "deviating" way" (Thornbury 71).

This underscores that Keiko, when viewed through a narrow lens, may seem unconventional or 'abnormal, but in narratives like *Convenience Store Woman*, individuals such as Keiko are portrayed as more ordinary than others. This study aligns with Thornbury's perspective, presenting Keiko's worldview as divergent from the norm while also serving as a revolutionary voice challenging accepted societal conventions.

It is recognised that her particular perspective and unconventional cognitive processes

have resulted in her marginalisation, yet the societal expectations placed upon her as a woman ultimately lead her to extensive subordination. From a feminist perspective, the novel portrays the struggles of a woman to fit herself into the already-existing normative society that alienates people who do

